

CAN FACTS REALLY BE SEPARATED FROM VALUES?

A visual introduction to Hilary Putnam's fact-value entanglement

**The ordinary picture looks clean.
Maybe too clean.**

FACTS

"The temperature is 90°F"



VALUES

"Cruelty is bad"

The traditional dichotomy

The picture we are about to test.

F = FACTS

observation
measurement
empirical claims
theory

V = VALUES

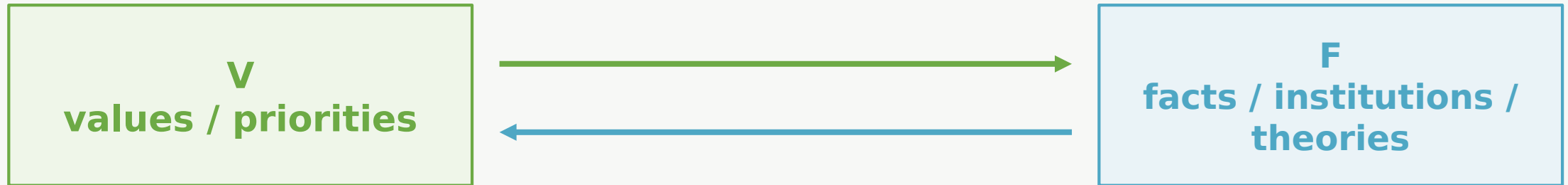
good / bad
right / wrong
rational / irrational
ought

$$F \cap V = \emptyset$$

The alleged boundary: description on one side, evaluation on the other.

The first crack: mutual influence

Even before Putnam, the clean wall starts leaking.



**Values select what gets
built, funded, measured.**

**Facts and consequences
reshape values next.**

law

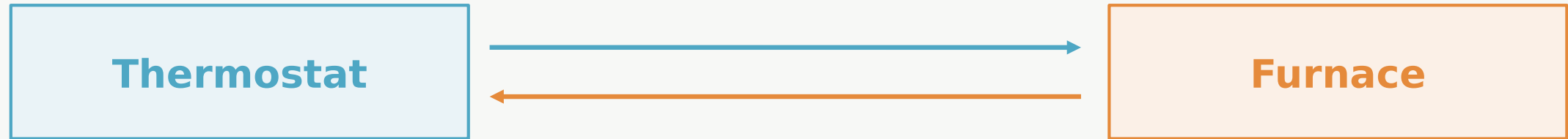
research

design

Interaction is real. But interaction alone is not yet Putnam.

Interaction is not yet entanglement

A useful objection keeps us honest.



They interact.

They remain distinct.

$V \rightarrow F$ and $F \rightarrow V$

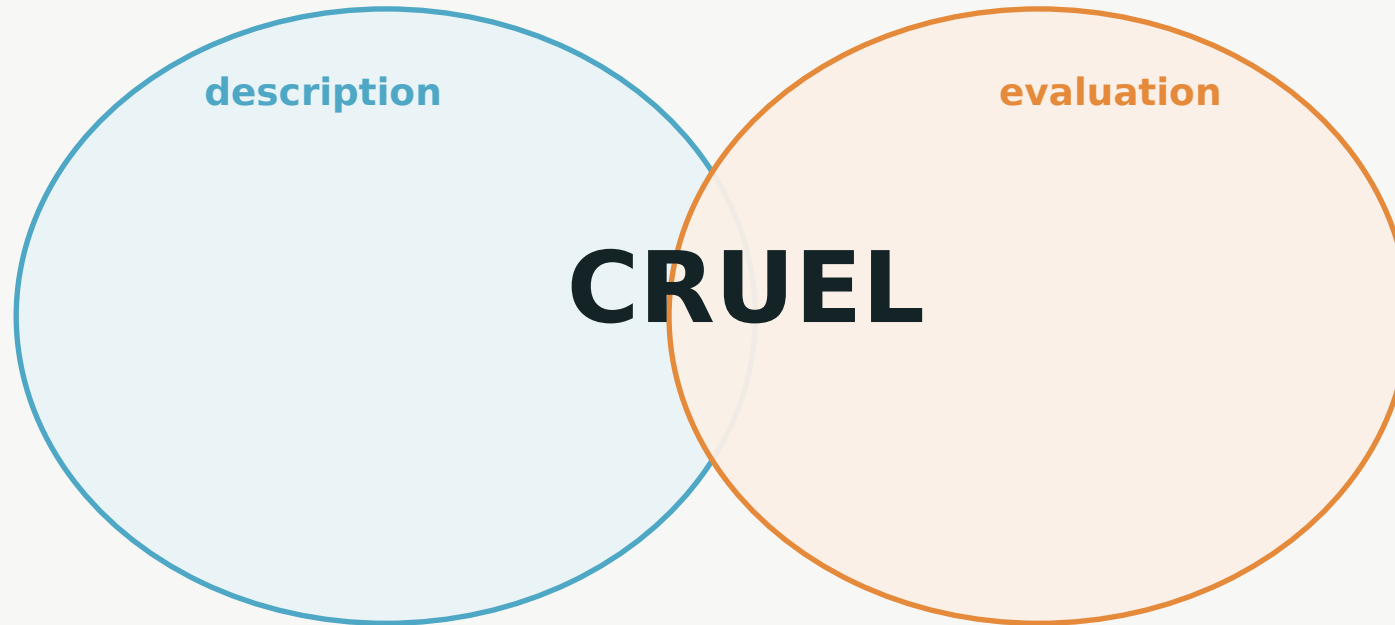
$\neq$

**conceptual
inseparability**

This slide blocks the sloppy version of the argument.

Enter the thick concept

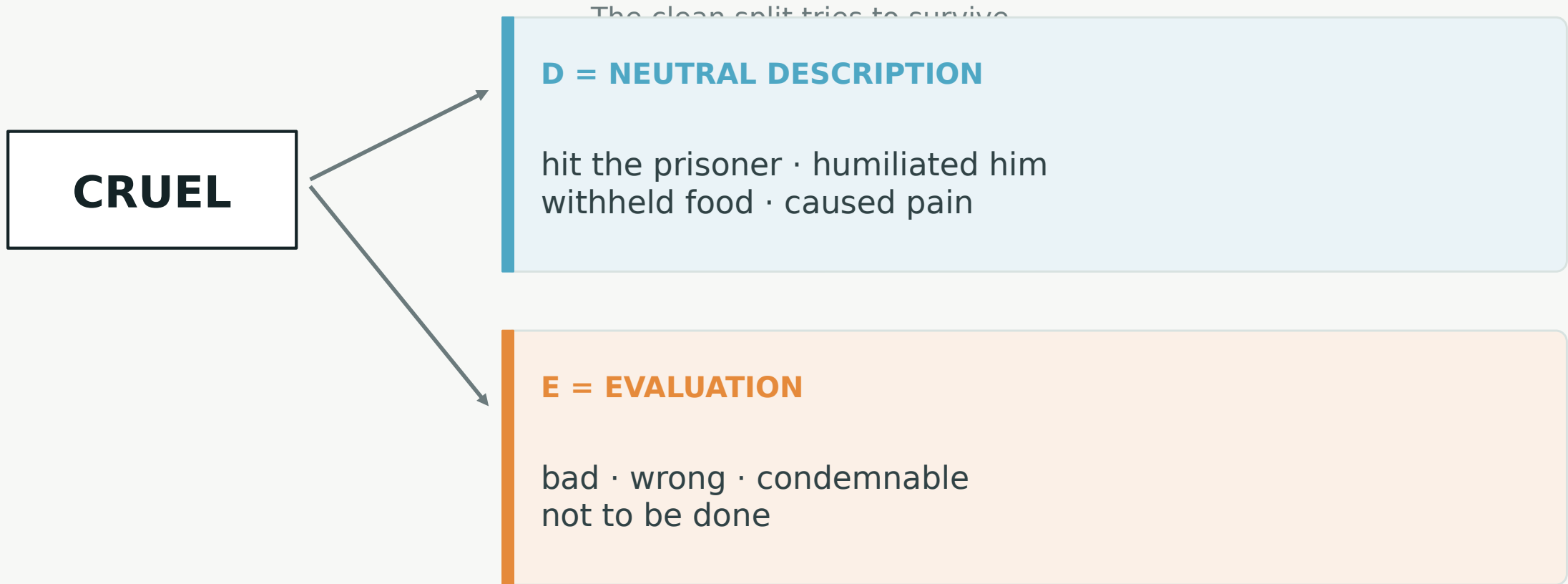
Putnam's pressure point is conceptual, not merely causal.



“The guard behaved cruelly toward the prisoner.”

A thick concept says what happened and how to assess it.

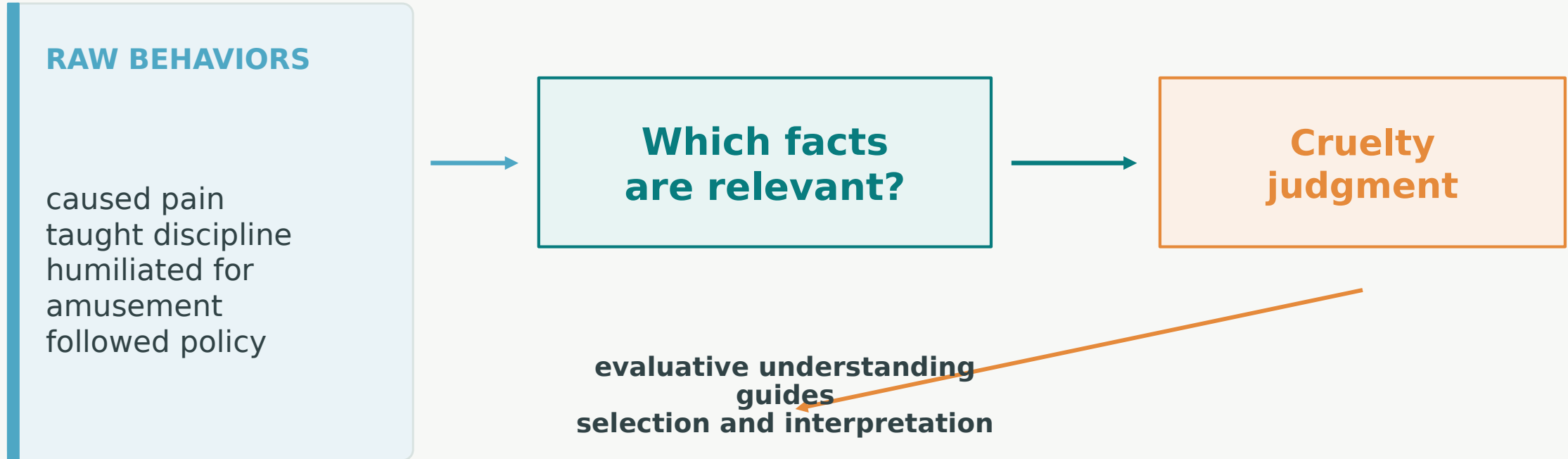
The tempting decomposition



Cruel = D + E ? That is the tempting rescue operation.

Putnam: not so fast

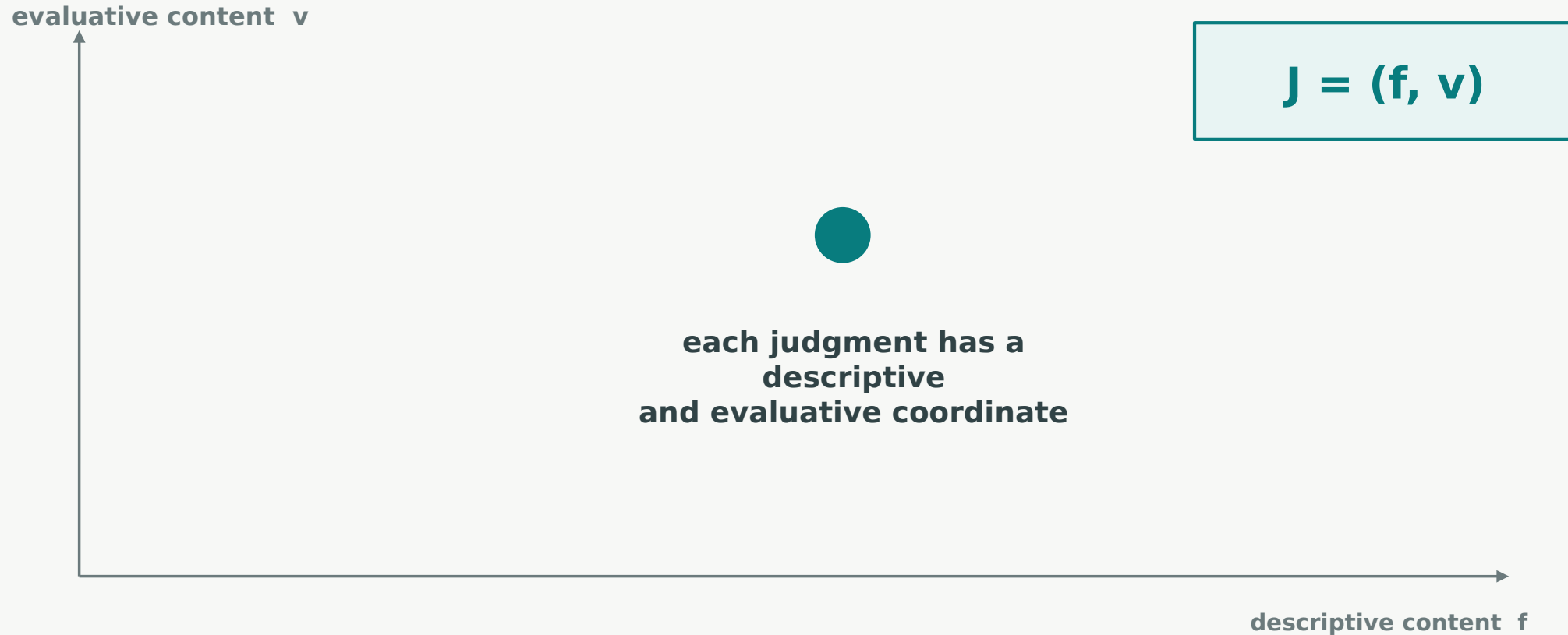
The value is not merely stapled on afterward.



To recognize the relevant facts as cruelty, you already need the evaluative concept.

A visual model of judgment

This is our map, not Putnam's math.



The model lets us avoid the dumb claim that facts and values are simply identical.

Some judgments lean descriptive

The model allows degrees.

evaluative content v

$$J_1 \approx (0.95, 0.05)$$

EXAMPLE

"The thermometer reads 22°C."



descriptive content f

Close to the descriptive axis does not mean metaphysically value-free.

Some judgments lean evaluative

The other extreme exists too.

evaluative content v



EXAMPLES

"That was admirable."
"That was disgusting."

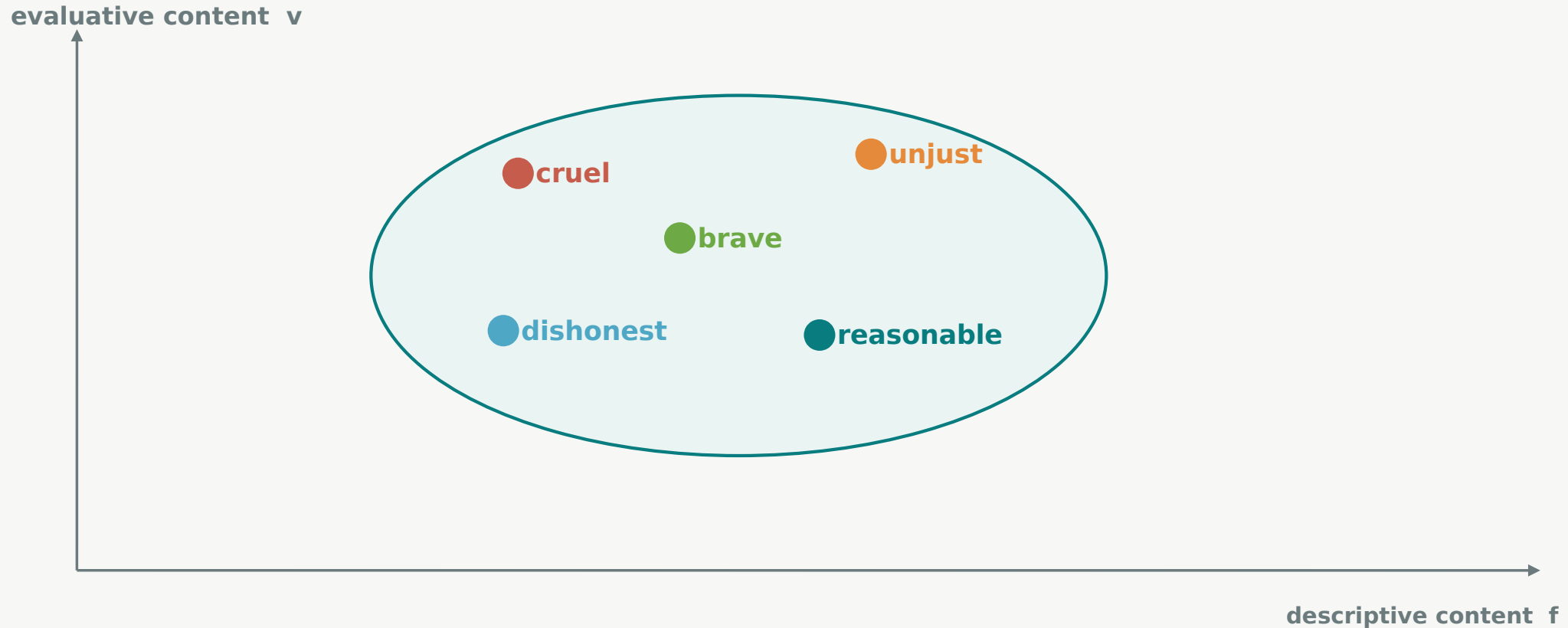
$$J_2 \approx (0.10, 0.90)$$

descriptive content f

Some claims are overwhelmingly evaluative without being empty of description.

The thick region

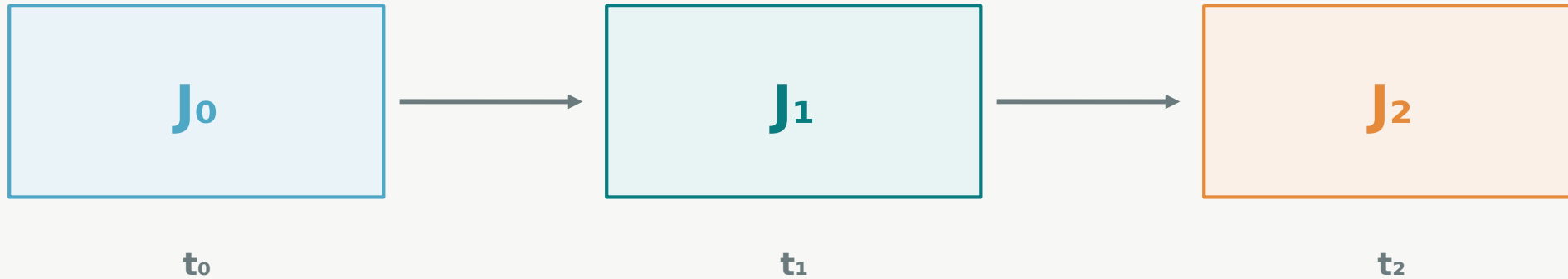
Much of human life sits in the middle.



Thick concepts occupy the zone where description and evaluation travel together.

Static entanglement is only the beginning

Now we let the picture move through time.

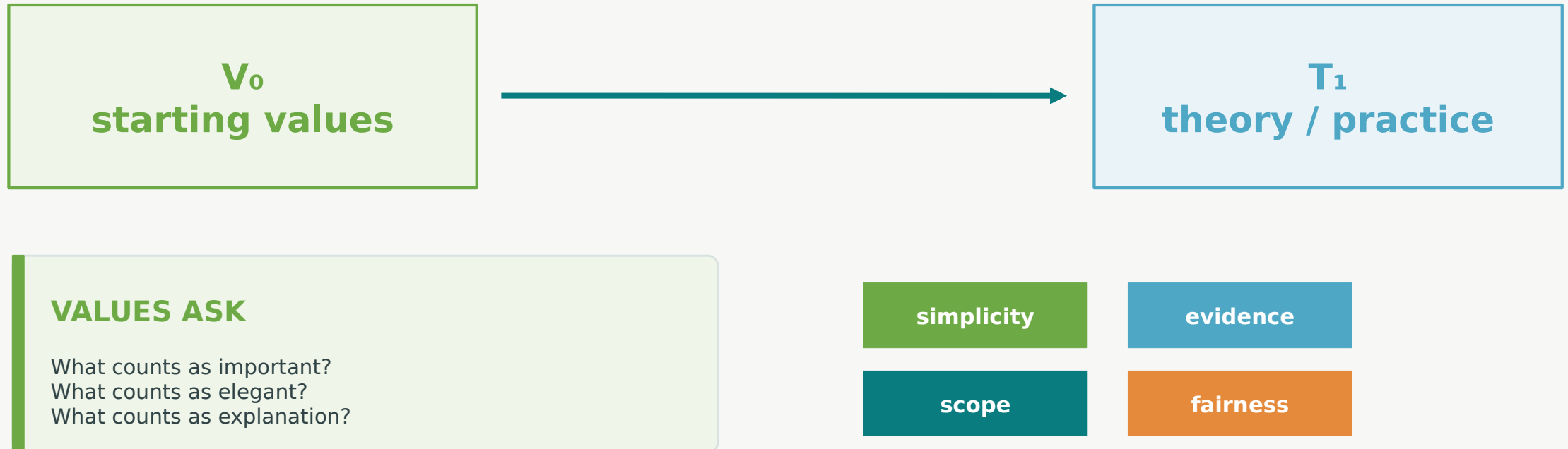


$$J_t = (f_t, v_t)$$

The judgment changes because both factual situation and evaluative orientation can change.

Values guide inquiry

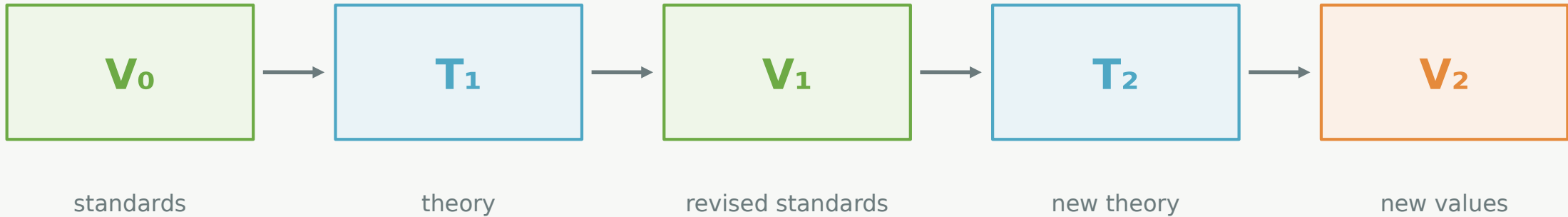
Inquiry starts with standards, interests, and priorities.



Values do not dictate the answer. They help determine the question and the standard of success.

Inquiry reshapes value

The return loop is where the machine gets interesting.

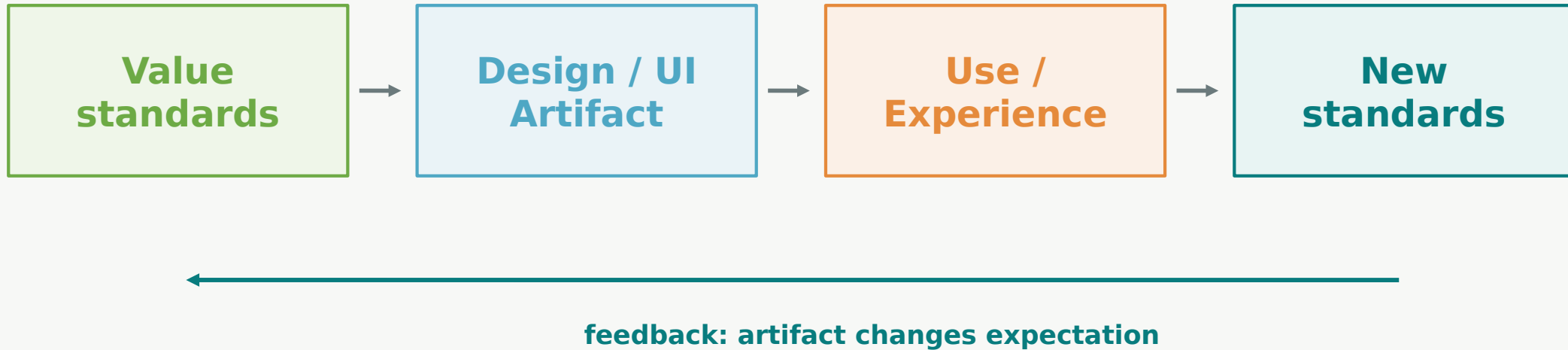


$$\mathbf{V_0 \rightarrow T_1 \rightarrow V_1 \rightarrow T_2 \rightarrow V_2 \rightarrow \dots}$$

Standards shape inquiry; successful inquiry can reshape standards.

Artifact loop

Values become things; things train future values.

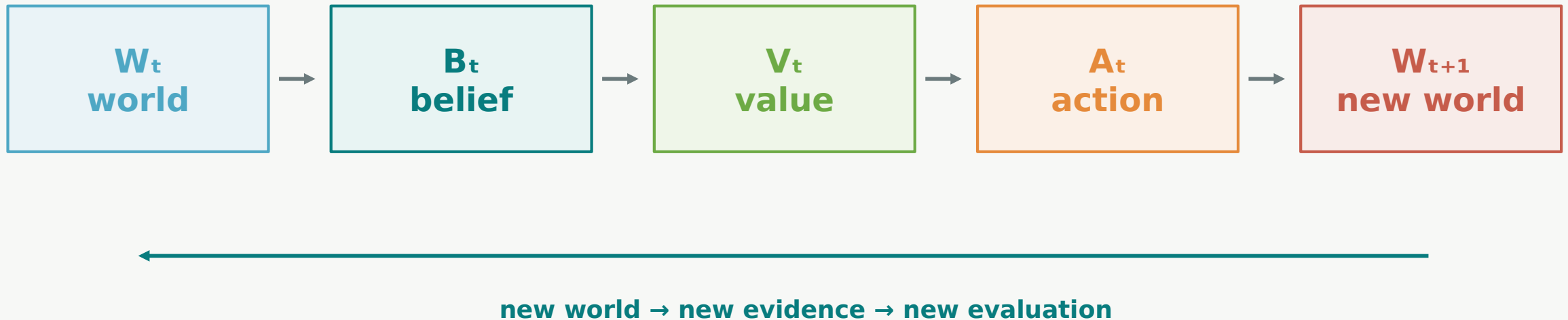


$$\mathbf{V_t \rightarrow A_t \rightarrow V_{t+1}}$$

Aesthetic and practical values shape artifacts; living with artifacts reshapes taste.

World, belief, value, action

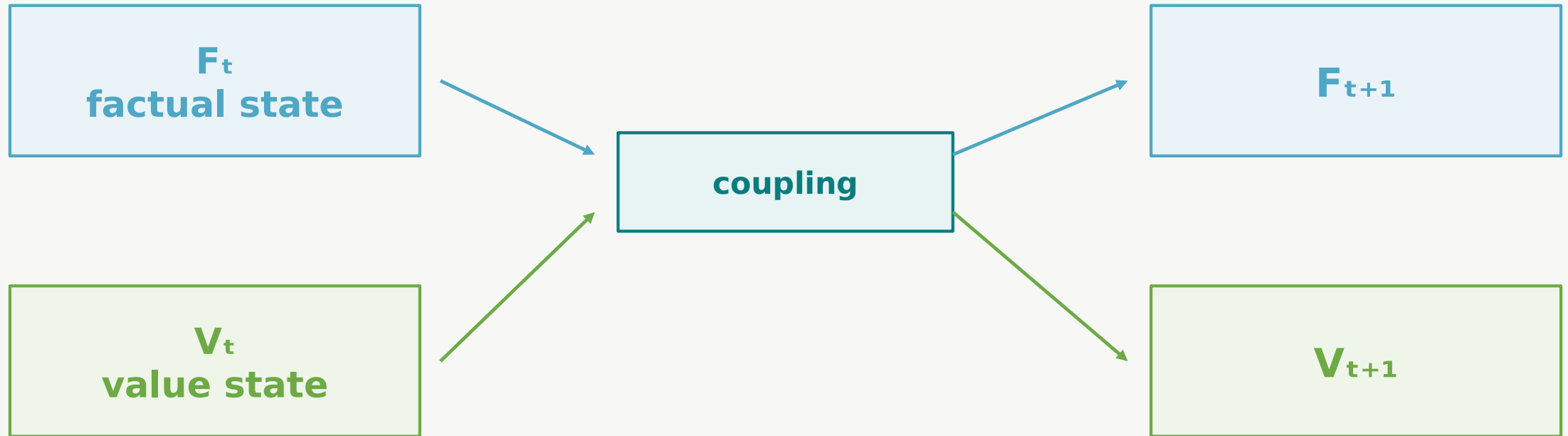
The agent-level feedback loop.



We do not merely observe state space. Evaluation helps choose the next state.

A coupled dynamical system

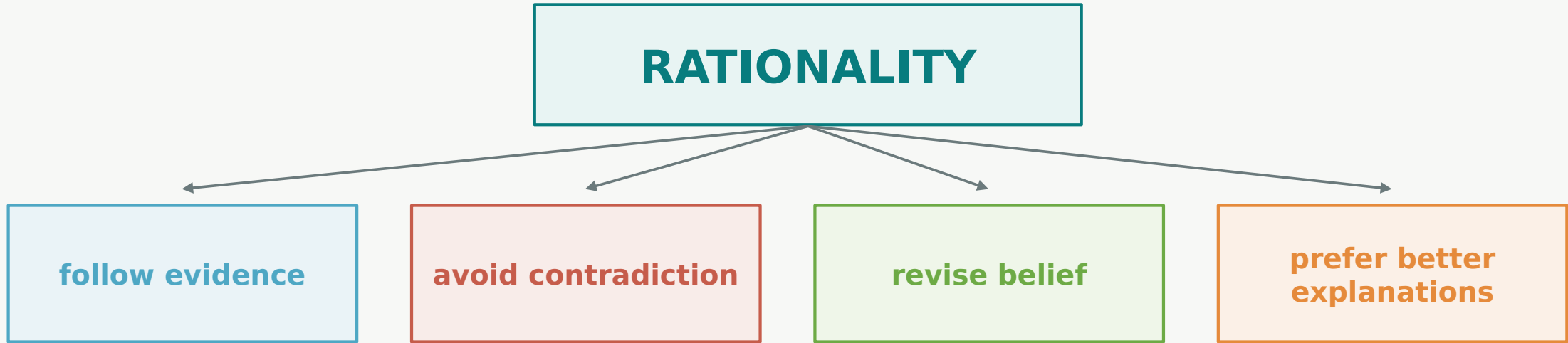
Not identical. Not independent.



$$(F_t, V_t) \mapsto (F_{t+1}, V_{t+1})$$

Rationality is already normative

The strongest “pure fact” refuge is not pure.



These are standards for how one ought to reason — not merely descriptions of what brains happen to do.

Strip out every norm and rationality collapses into causal psychology.

Conclusion

Distinguishable does not mean cleanly separable.

$$F \neq V$$

**F and V
are not independent**

$$(F_t, V_t) \rightarrow (F_{t+1}, V_{t+1})$$

1. Not identical
2. Not sealed off
3. Often dynamically entangled

Putnam's point is not that facts are values. It is that our best descriptions and evaluations often cannot be cleanly pulled apart.